Session 19

2025-08-19

1 - The chalice revealed

~08:00, 12 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Morning in **Olver**'s *El Reposo en el Camino*. The heavy rain that broke over the roof the night before is still coming down. The party gather in the privacy of their upstairs room and Mialee shows what she lifted the previous night. A **golden chalice**, its interior crusted with old blood, from the chest she had picked aboard the cultist wagon. Along with it a bundle of other valuables of the same cut — plate, buckle-work, a short knife with chased hilt — read by the party as loot that could as easily have come out of **Greenest** weeks before.
2. The chalice is treated as confirmation of what the party has long suspected about the three merchant wagons at the front of the caravan: cultists in the convoy, from the same operation that burned Greenest. The question in the room shifts from *are they* to *how do we move on it before Waterdeep*.

2 - A matter of horses

1. By mid-morning the common room has thinned, and **Lord Eldrin Kaldur** crosses it to the long table where the lead merchants are working through their own accounts. His knight **Jaxen Korrith**, who doubles as the cart's driver, stands a pace behind him in half-armour; his wizard **Thalor Cheston** keeps apart at the hearth, warming his hands.
2. The nobleman's pitch is brief: he and his are bound for Waterdeep, their cargo cannot wait on an escort of their own, and he would travel in company to the city rather than risk the open road alone. The merchants weigh it and agree. A travel-share is settled and a handshake is given.
3. The business of his horses is the longer conversation. Lord Kaldur does not conceal his contempt for the beasts — useless, hollow-flanked, half-dead on the yoke, and sure to founder before Waterdeep without a change. He will buy fresh horses from any merchant at the table who will sell, and he will not haggle over the price.
4. The merchants exchange looks and refuse: they need every animal they have for the days ahead. Lord Kaldur receives the refusal with ill grace and blames the gods for his luck.
5. From their own corner of the room the party watch the display over the dregs of breakfast. Nuberroca, who still carries the murmured *cursed mutants* that came through the closed door at him the night before, leans back on his bench and remarks loud enough to carry that between him and the lord, he is still working out which of them is the mutant.

3 - Fired at the inn

1. At the common-room tables, the **Company of the Boar** — **Jorath Vexundar**, **Kaldan Voss**, **Thorvin Caldorath**, and **Khorvalis** — close a hire with the merchants. The pitch wins out: four seasoned sellswords with trolls on the road not many days ahead. The rate the Company names is near the top of what the caravan's purse can bear; the merchants cannot stretch it to cover two guard contingents at once.
2. The merchants trim the roll on the spot. Amidamaru, Mialee, Nuberroca, and Kaelthar are paid out what they are owed to the day and let go; Nyx and Eguzkilore are kept on. The four released are welcome to keep travelling with the caravan — safer in company than alone, and the merchants are not above the trade — but without pay from that point.
3. The party take the decision badly and say so to the merchants' faces: this is a mistake, the Company of the Boar will not do the work that the party have done, and the merchants will come to see it before Waterdeep. The warning is heard and the merchants do not change their minds.
4. Nuberroca carries the point across to the Company's table and presses Khorvalis again for the duel he had tried for the night before — if the merchants mean to pay the Company's four over the party's six, then let the two companies' strongest settle on the common-room floor what the merchants have not settled in coin. Khorvalis declines the same way he had the night before: he reserves his strength for real enemies, and he will not brawl in a tavern for the amusement of merchants.
5. Lord Kaldur picks Kaelthar up on the spot as his own personal guard the moment the paladin is cut loose. The arrangement is private and settled by a short exchange at the noble's table.
6. Nuberroca, unwilling to walk the road for nothing, makes his own arrangement before the caravan sets out — a modest family travelling farther back in the line, **Darla** and her husband **Gus the humble** and their quiet friend **Anton**, take him on as guard for the price of a share of their food. He will ride by their wagon from that point.
7. Amidamaru finds Thorvin Caldorath at a corner table and closes a transaction long in the making: a flask of magical ink from the warlock's own supply, for a hefty sum of gold. **Munin** rides on his shoulder through the exchange, dry and preening after a long night under the rain. The ink is standard-priced for its kind. The scribing work that has waited on it since the first days of the caravan can now begin.

4 – North in the rain

~12:00, 12 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The caravan rolls out of the inn into the rain later on 12 Uktar. The Company of the Boar ride at the merchants' flanks under their new contract; Lord Kaldur's cart rolls with them under the travel-share settled that morning, Kaelthar walking close by the noble's wagon as his hired guard. The three bound captives still walk tied at the back of the line.
2. Mialee works the gaps between the carts unseen through the day, listening in where the cultist drivers think themselves alone. She catches a line among them that will not leave her head — the cargo must reach **Naerytar** — spoken as a place rather than a person. She brings it back to the party at the next halt.
3. The name reaches Nyx, who, pressed on it, strains to place it and comes up with the barest flicker: she has read it somewhere in Greenest, perhaps a castle, nothing more. The party set it aside as something to ask after on the road to Waterdeep.
4. The ride out from the inn gives the party the full measure of why the beasts are in the state they are in. From his wagon-seat Lord Kaldur drives the pace from the back, calling the lash down on the horses' flanks through Jaxen Korrith's hand whenever they slow in the mud; no slackening at the climbs, no stop at the verges for grass, no breath at the water-crossings. Within hours the yoke-sores on both animals are weeping fresh under the harness, and the near horse is dragging its off-side hoof. The party watch it from down the line and keep their peace.
5. By the first halt Lord Kaldur is at the merchants' side again with the same offer and the same complaint he aired at the inn; the answer is the same. Amidamaru walks over to the noble's team while the argument carries, lays hands on each animal in turn and draws the worst of the wounds closed, then gathers grass by the handful from the verge and feeds them where their driver has not, and takes a few long minutes to comb the mud and tangles out of their manes. He will come back to them more than once on the road ahead.
6. The rest of the day carries on in the same ordinary flow of caravan travel in autumn rain: wheel-ruts filling, the midday meal on the wagons, watches cycled, the four unpaid keeping their own counsel at the back of the line. The caravan makes camp when the light begins to go, and the rain has not stopped once since the inn.

5 – A soaked day

~07:00, 13 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Camp strikes with everything already heavy — bedding, cloaks, boots, saddlebags soaked through the night under rain that has not slackened. Nothing dried, nothing warm, no fire to be had on the open road.
2. The ride is worse than yesterday's. Wheel-ruts have gone to channels of running water, the horses blow muddy clouds at every step, the carts slip sideways on the climbs and come near-lost at two of the water-crossings. Cloaks hang like lead on shoulders by midday; boots fill at every patch of flooded road; and the rain is still falling.
3. Amidamaru moves up the line to tend Lord Kaldur's team again at each halt — healing, feeding, combing out their coats as he can; the noble's demands on the horses have not softened, and without the artificer's hands the near beast would have gone down by now.

6 – Stones for bedding

~21:00, 13 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The caravan reaches the night's camping place as the last of the light goes — the Trade Way has brought them to the northern edge of the **Fields of the Dead**, with the **Trollclaws** ahead. The rain is still falling. The ground is a pond.
2. Nyx hits on the idea that will save them a night on the saturated earth: she gathers a pile of flat stones and lays them under her sleeping mat as a dry platform. The others copy the trick for their own beds along the roadside. The camp is in small clusters on both sides of the road: the party together on one verge, the Company of the Boar and the three suspected cultist wagons on the other.
3. Kaelthar sleeps apart on the far side, close by Lord Kaldur's cart — the paladin keeps his watch where his new sworn duty lies. Nuberroca sleeps nearer the back, by the family's wagon.
4. Watches are set and the party go down one by one. The rain is still falling as the last of them finds sleep.